ITT06105 • DESKTOP PUBLISHING

INTRODUCTION TO

DOCUMENT LAYOUT

WITH ADOBE INDESIGN

Lecture 07 | Diploma in Information Technology

From Photoshop image + Illustrator icon → A4 educational hand-out

Academic year 2026/2027

What you will learn

Five practical outcomes for this lecture.

1	**Understand**	Explain what page-layout software does and recognise InDesign workspace parts.
2	**Set up**	Create a single A4 portrait page with a consistent content margin.
3	**Place**	Use text frames and image frames correctly.
4	**Organise**	Build a simple visual hierarchy using alignment and spacing.
5	**Save**	Keep an editable INDD and export an initial PDF proof.

Prepared work from earlier lessons becomes the content for the new page.

One project, three applications

COURSE CONNECTION

PHOTOSHOP

Prepare and crop a suitable photograph.

→

ILLUSTRATOR

Draw a clear, scalable icon.

→

INDESIGN

Arrange image, icon and text on an A4 page.

The three applications are complementary. We do not need to learn every advanced tool in order to create a useful publication.

KEY CONCEPT

What is document layout?

Think about how the reader experiences the page.

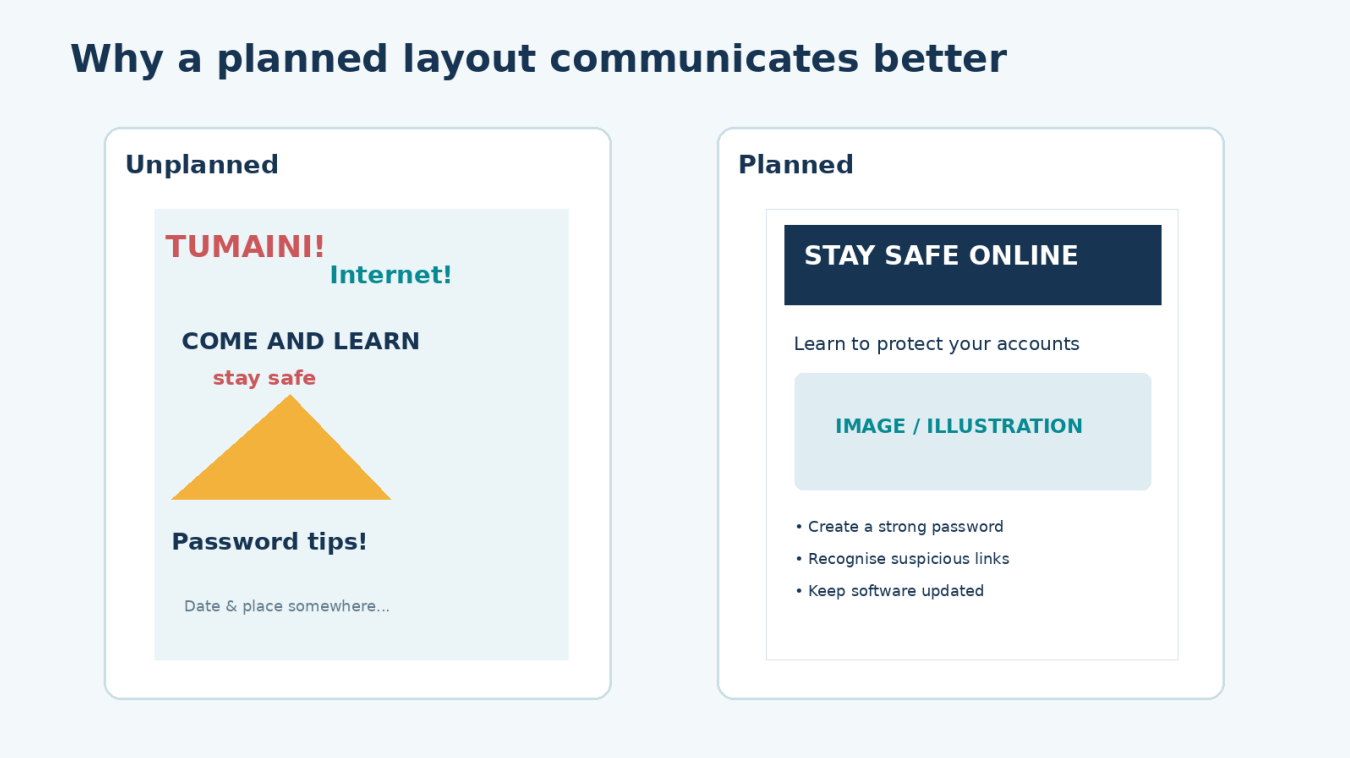
Definition

Document layout is the planned arrangement of text, images, shapes and open space on a page. Its purpose is to make information easy to notice, understand and use.

A well-designed educational hand-out should have a clear title, an illustration, short advice and a footer.

Good layout makes the message easier to follow

Compare the crowded page with the organised version.



Design for the reader

The planned version creates a clear order. The main message appears first, related information stays together, and spacing helps the reader find the three essential tips.

Why use Adobe InDesign?

InDesign specialises in organising pages and publications.

InDesign is a page-layout application

It allows a designer to create pages, manage text frames and graphic frames, place prepared images, align elements and export a publication as PDF. Photoshop and Illustrator remain useful for preparing the images and graphics before placing them.

Our goal is a one-page A4 hand-out — not an advanced magazine or multi-page book.

Choose the appropriate application

Three tools, three primary tasks.

Editing an image

Use Photoshop or a similar editor for cropping, tonal correction and preparing pixel-based photographs. Those edits should happen before the image is placed into the page layout.

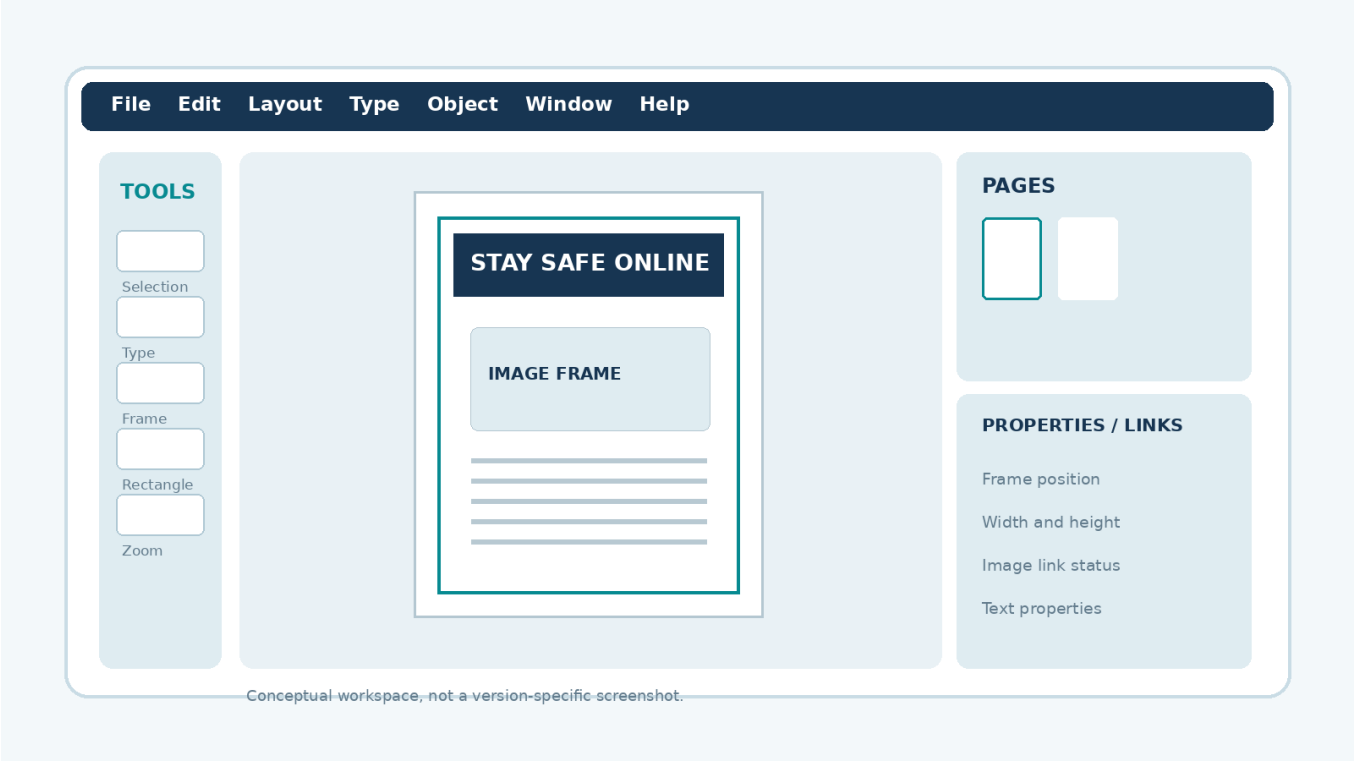
Designing a publication

Use InDesign to arrange the headline, image, short paragraphs and footer on a page. It manages the composition without permanently changing the original picture.

ILLUSTRATION

Recognising the workspace

A conceptual overview — menus and panel locations may differ by version.



Conceptual workspace, not a version-specific screenshot.

What you need today

Locate the Tools panel, document page, pasteboard, Pages panel and Properties or Links panel. Their exact position is less important than knowing what each part is used for.

EXPLAIN

The page and the pasteboard

These two areas serve different purposes.

Page

The page is the defined publication area. Text and graphics placed inside it may appear in the exported PDF. For this lesson, the page is one A4 portrait sheet.

Pasteboard

The space around the page helps you temporarily store objects while arranging the layout. Objects outside the page are usually not part of the final exported page.

KEY CONCEPT

The panels support different tasks

Learn the job of each panel, not every menu option.

Essential workspace controls

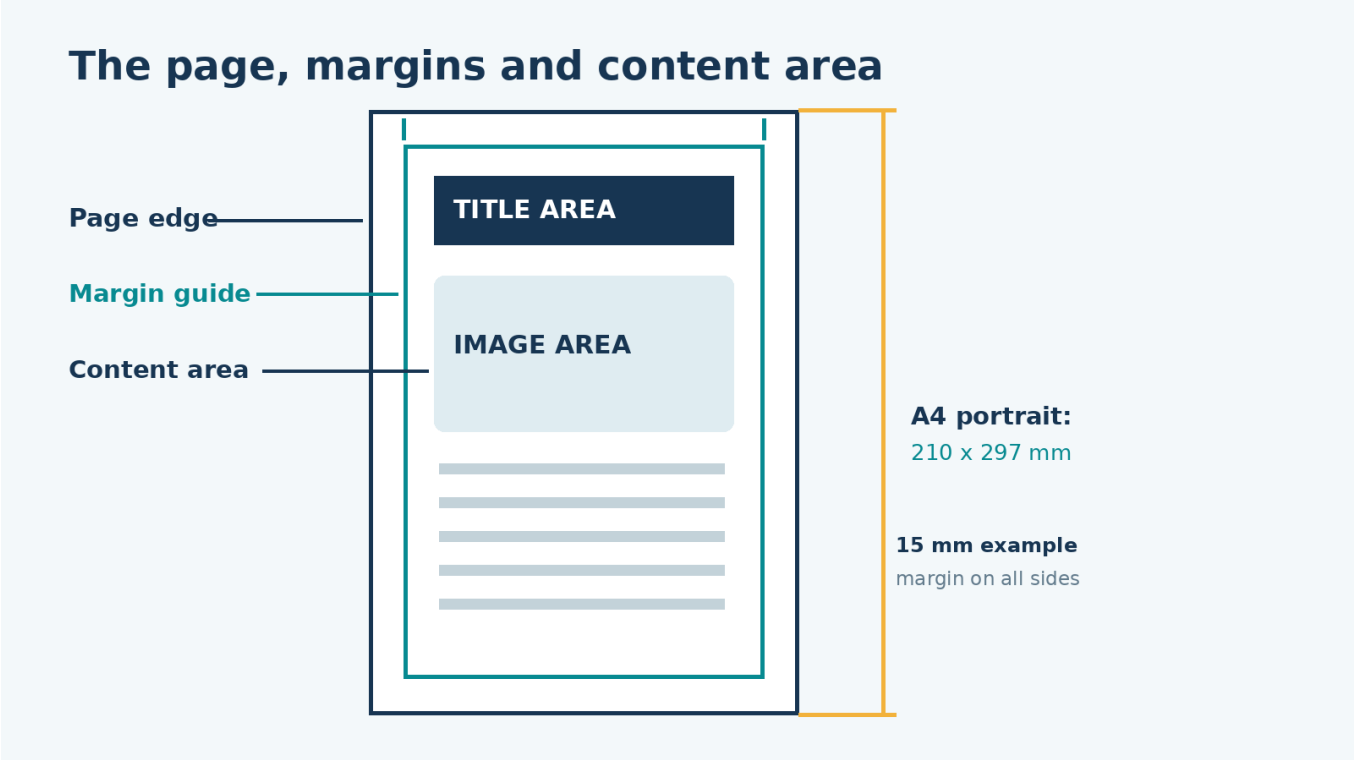
Tools create or select page objects. Pages helps navigate and organise pages. Properties or Control changes object characteristics, while Links helps locate and update placed images.

Tip: Start by finding the Selection tool, Type tool, Pages panel and the page itself.

ILLUSTRATION

Page setup: A4 portrait

Our classroom example uses an A4 page and 15 mm margins.



Essential dimensions

An A4 portrait page is 210 mm wide and 297 mm high. Margins provide breathing space between the page edge and the content. They can be adjusted later if a printer gives different requirements.

Quick calculation: usable page width

A4 page with 15 mm left and right margins.

TRY IT

How much width remains for text and pictures after the two side margins?

Width = 210 − 15 − 15 = 180 mm. Explain why this matters before arranging your frames.

Quick calculation: usable page height

Use the same 15 mm top and bottom margins.

TRY IT

If the A4 page height is 297 mm, how much vertical space remains inside the margins?

Height = 297 − 15 − 15 = 267 mm. This is the approximate content region for our classroom layout.

KEY CONCEPT

Margins and guides are not borders

They organise where content should sit.

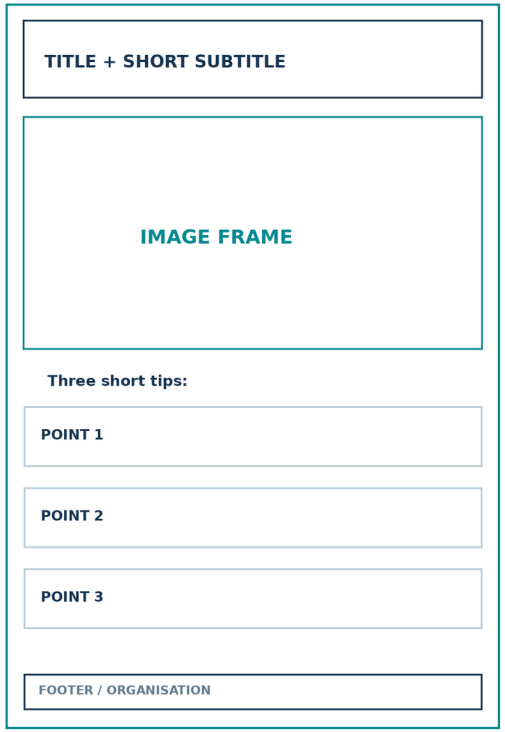
Margin versus guide

A margin is an intended clear space near a page edge. Guides are reference lines that help align titles, photos and paragraphs. They are usually visible while editing but are not printed as part of the content.

The easiest beginner rule is to keep the important text and graphics inside the margin guides.

Begin with a wireframe

A simple sketch prevents misplaced content later.

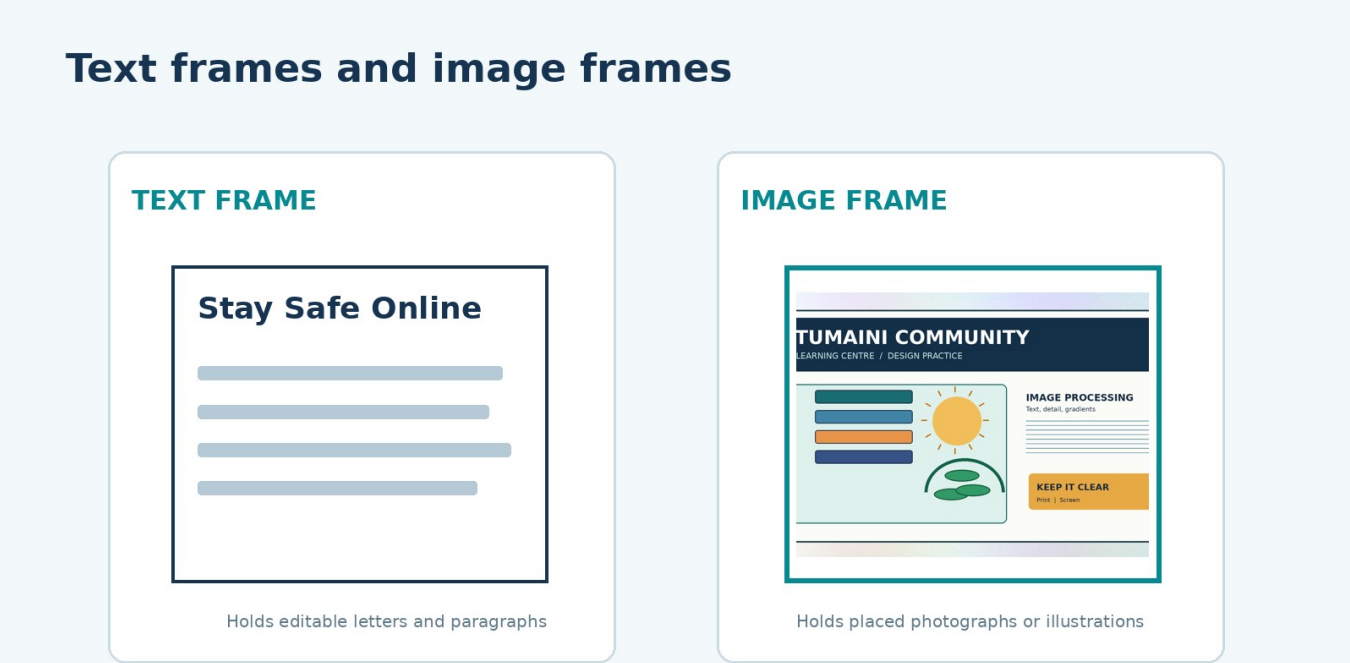


What to sketch

Mark a large title area, a short subtitle, one photograph, three brief tips and a small footer. Decide the order before you start resizing text and images on a computer.

Text frames and image frames

They contain different kinds of material.



Two essential containers

A text frame holds editable letters and paragraphs. An image frame displays a photograph or illustration that has been placed into the publication. You can move or resize each frame independently.

KEY CONCEPT

What is a text frame?

The words remain editable within the layout.

Text frame

A text frame is a rectangular or other defined area that contains text. Use a frame for your title, subtitle, body tips or footer. Adjusting frame size changes how the words flow; it does not mean that the words themselves have changed.

Create a headline that can be read immediately, then add short supporting paragraphs.

KEY CONCEPT

What is an image frame?

Think of the frame as a window onto a picture.

Graphic or image frame

An image frame displays an imported graphic. You can move or crop the visible portion without changing the original image file. The frame and the image inside it can be adjusted separately, so use fitting options carefully.

Place the prepared image from Lecture 5 instead of searching for a new photograph.

Placing a prepared image

The basic File > Place workflow.

1	**Find**	Make sure the image is saved inside your project folder.
2	**Place**	In InDesign, choose File > Place and select the file.
3	**Position**	Click a prepared frame or drag an appropriately sized frame.
4	**Fit**	Keep the image in proportion; adjust the crop if required.

Avoid stretching the picture

Poor fitting and hidden text are different problems.

Two common problems: poor fitting and overset text

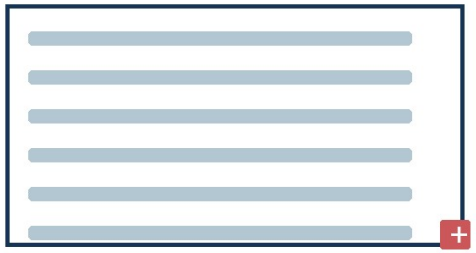
IMAGE IS STRETCHED



Do not stretch images out of proportion.

Fit or crop while keeping the aspect ratio.

TEXT IS OVERSET



A red plus may indicate hidden text.

Resize the frame or edit the text.

A common beginner mistake

Stretching only the width or the height makes people and objects look unnatural. Fit the picture proportionally. If text is hidden, enlarge the text frame or simplify the wording.

KEY CONCEPT

What is overset text?

Important words should never disappear from the export.

Overset text

Overset text is text that is stored in a frame but does not fit inside the visible area. InDesign may show a small red plus on the text frame. The reader cannot reliably see the hidden material in the exported publication.

Always check that all three safety tips appear completely in the PDF proof.

EXPLAIN

Build a clear visual hierarchy

Do not use the same size and weight for every line.

What should be noticed first?

The title “Stay Safe Online” must be the most prominent text. It tells readers immediately what the hand-out is about. Use a larger size and a position near the top.

What should follow?

The one-sentence explanation introduces the topic, followed by the main image and three short practical tips. The organisation name belongs in the footer and can be smaller.

EXPLAIN

Alignment and spacing improve readability

Simple consistency is more useful than decoration.

Alignment

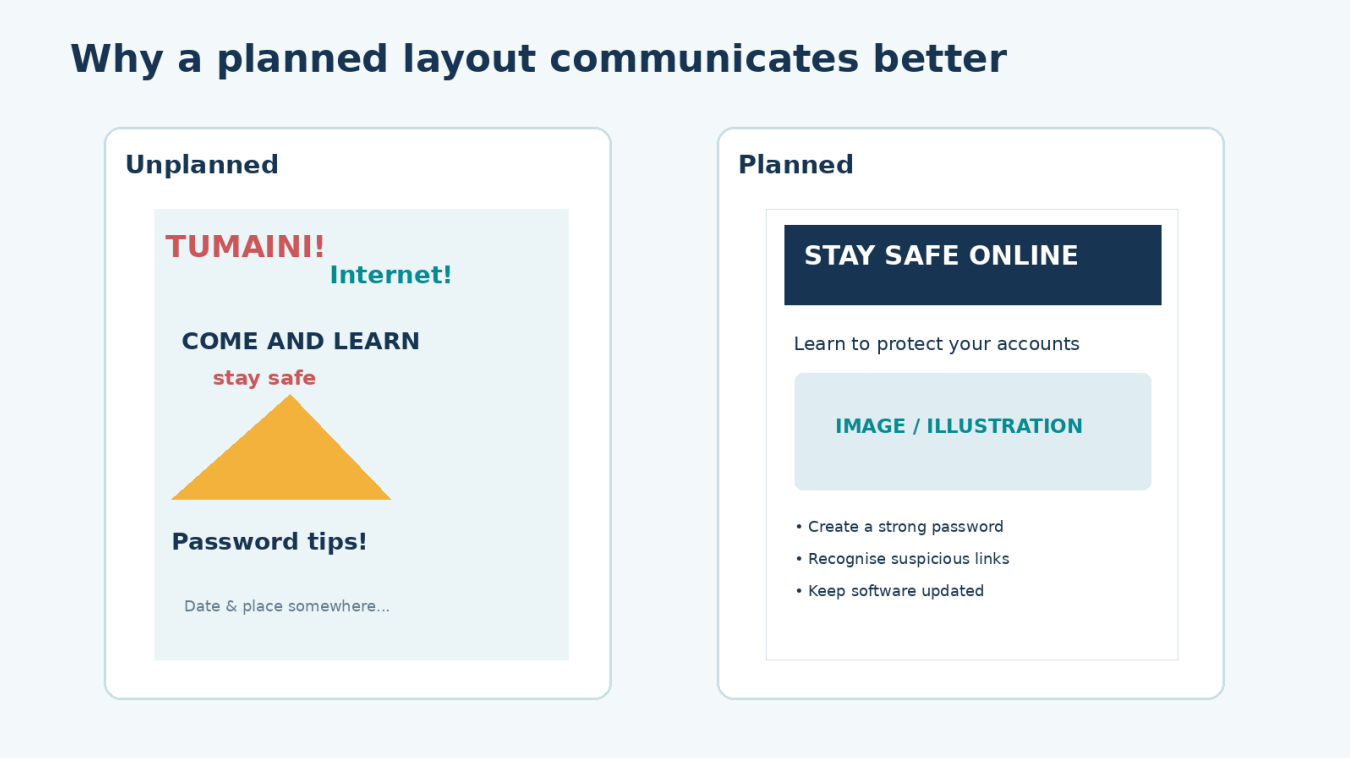
Use the same left edge for related text frames. A title, subtitle and body points that line up feel like parts of the same publication.

White space

Leave enough space around groups of information. Do not fill every area of the page; the empty space helps separate unrelated blocks and makes reading easier.

See the planned and unplanned versions

Notice how the clear design uses fewer distractions.



Apply what you already know

This lecture reuses the design principles from Lecture 1: contrast, alignment, proximity and hierarchy. The layout should make the main information easy to locate.

MODEL OUTPUT

Your model hand-out: Stay Safe Online

Use the example as a guide, not as a requirement to copy every detail.



STAY SAFE
ONLINE

A quick guide for new computer users

LEARNING CENTRE / DESIGN PRACTICE

IMAGE PROCESSING
Text, detail, gradients

KEEP IT CLEAR
Print | Screen

Three habits that make a difference

1 **Use strong, unique passwords**
Avoid using your name or a common number.

2 **Think before clicking links**
Check the sender and the website address.

3 **Protect your devices**
Install updates and lock your screen.

TUMAINI COMMUNITY LEARNING CENTRE
Educational sample — contact details to be added by your instructor.

Expected page structure

A title, short subtitle, one main image, three short tips and a footer. You will create the basic skeleton in Lecture 7, then refine and proof the hand-out in Lecture 8.

Practical — Stage 1: create the project

Start by keeping the source files organised.

1	**Folder**	Create a folder named L07_Tumaini_Handout.
2	**Assets**	Copy the prepared image, lightbulb icon and practice text into it.
3	**Document**	Open InDesign and create one A4 portrait page.
4	**Margins**	Set all margins to 15 mm for the classroom exercise.

Practical — Stage 2: make the page skeleton

Use only the tools needed for this first draft.

1	**Headline**	Draw a text frame at the top and type STAY SAFE ONLINE.
2	**Image**	Create a graphic frame and place the prepared picture.
3	**Tips**	Add three short safety tips in one or more text frames.
4	**Footer**	Write TUMAINI COMMUNITY LEARNING CENTRE at the bottom.

Practical — Stage 3: refine the basics

A clean first draft matters more than special effects.

1	**Check title**	Can the headline be read without effort?
2	**Check image**	Is the image in proportion and suitably placed?
3	**Check spacing**	Are frames aligned within margins with a little space between them?
4	**Check text**	Can you see the complete wording of every tip?

SAVING

Editable working file versus PDF proof

Both are needed for an efficient publishing workflow.

INDD document

The .indd file is the editable source. It preserves layout frames, editable text, images placed into the publication and page settings. You need it when making changes in the next lesson.

A PDF is a document to inspect or share; it does not replace your editable InDesign source file.

Practical — Stage 4: save and export

Keep a working document and a proof.

1	**Save first**	Save Tumaini_Handout_Draft.indd in your project folder.
2	**Export**	Choose File > Export and select a PDF output.
3	**Name**	Save Tumaini_Handout_Draft.pdf.
4	**Review**	Open the PDF and check the page from top to bottom.

Why placed images can become missing links

The design file may refer to a separate source image.

Image links

InDesign can place graphics as linked assets. The document refers to those image files, which remain stored in your project folder. If the files are renamed or moved, the Links panel may warn that the image is missing or modified.

Keep the source image and INDD file organised in the same project folder and avoid unnecessary renaming.

Diagnose two avoidable problems

Use this illustration to guide your quality check.

Two common problems: poor fitting and overset text

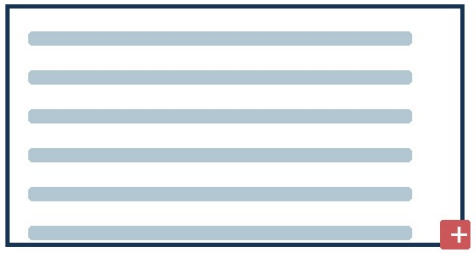
IMAGE IS STRETCHED



Do not stretch images out of proportion.

Fit or crop while keeping the aspect ratio.

TEXT IS OVERSET



A red plus may indicate hidden text.

Resize the frame or edit the text.

How to correct errors

For a distorted photograph, restore the correct proportions. For hidden text, enlarge or reposition the frame, or shorten the wording. Always export a fresh PDF after making corrections.

Check your understanding

Look at the first-draft hand-out.

TRY IT

If a heading is outside the page margin and the final tip is hidden, what two corrections should you make?

Move or resize the heading frame inside the margin; fix the overset body text before re-exporting.

Choose the right file

Suppose you need to change a sentence next week.

TRY IT

Would you reopen the editable .indd document or edit the PDF proof, and why?

Open the .indd document because it preserves editable text and page frames. Then export an updated PDF proof.

Final draft checklist

Use this before you submit your Lecture 7 activity.

1	**Page**	A4 portrait, one page, 15 mm classroom margins.
2	**Message**	Readable title, short introduction and three complete tips.
3	**Artwork**	Image placed in proportion; optional icon included.
4	**Files**	Save INDD, open and check the PDF proof.

PRACTICAL ALTERNATIVE

No InDesign access today?

The concepts can still be practised on paper.

Paper-based route

Sketch an A4 page with a title frame, image frame, three tip blocks and footer. Label margins and explain the reading order. You can later reproduce the sketch in the computer laboratory using the supplied assets.

The paper route supports learning, but a software-produced file is still the intended digital output when access becomes available.

Short revision exercise

Bring together the main ideas from this lesson.

TRY IT

State one purpose for each: page margins, text frame, graphic frame, PDF proof.

Sample: margins create a clear boundary; text frame holds editable words; graphic frame displays an image; PDF proof allows the result to be checked.

Key ideas to remember

A good layout helps readers use the information.

Five essentials

Plan before arranging. Choose A4 portrait and suitable margins. Use text and graphic frames for different content. Keep the page aligned and readable. Save the editable INDD and check the exported PDF.

Your goal today is a well-structured first draft — Lecture 8 will concentrate on refinement and final proofing.

Keep your draft editable so that you can improve and proofread it.

Next: complete and proof the hand-out

WHAT COMES NEXT

NEXT LESSON

Refine your headings, spacing and images; fix overflow; inspect the PDF; and prepare a complete one-page educational hand-out.

Bring your INDD source, placed image, lightbulb icon and first PDF proof.